including Mission to Planet Earth, Space Station, Space Science and Aeronautics.

State Legislative Initiatives

In May 11, 1995, the state legislature of **Alaska** authorized the funding for a commercial **spaceport** on Kodiak Island, a prime site for launching polar-orbit satellites. Also, a satellite tracking, control and data facility is planned in Fairbanks for commercial endeavors. Other states contending to launch commercial spaceports include California, Colorado, Florida, Hawaii, Mississippi, New Mexico and Virginia.

Executive Actions

Executive Order 12951 (Feb. 22. 1995) provides a comprehensive and exclusive system for the public release, within 18 months, of certain scientifically or environmentally useful imagery acquired by space-based national intelligence reconnaissance systems (Corona, Argon, & Lanyard).

On September 29, President Clinton also issued his administration's policy on the use of foreign ballistic missiles which have been converted for space launch. The administration will now review on a case-by-case basis requests to launch U.S. commercial satellites on these foreign missiles. The decision will have an immediate impact on Russia's and Ukraine's quest to compete with U.S. launchers. Russia's SS-25 missile has already been modified for orbital launches and is currently being marketed, and Ukraine's SS-18 missile could be modified to launch satellites as well. Subsequent to the policy announcement, the U.S. State Department granted EarthWatch Inc. permission to launch its remote-sensing satellite on the converted Russian SS-25 missile.

International Developments

Under a recent contract between NASA and SPACEHAB Space Research Laboratory (a pressurized, cylindrical module that flies on board the space shuttle payload bay), four space shuttle missions would begin with STS-76 which is scheduled for launch in March 1996 and is to be docked to the **Russian** Mir to conduct commercially sponsored experiments.

An agreement between NASA's space station prime contractor, **Boeing** Defense and Space Group, and Russia's State Research and Production Space Center (**Khrunichev**) provides for the completion, delivery, launch, and on-orbit checkout in November 1997 of the functional energy block, a modified Russian spacecraft, to be used for on-orbit construction on the international space station.

The Topex-Poseidon Project, a joint program coordinated by NASA and the French Space Agency (CNES), continued for a third year its study of the role of oceans in the evolution of our planet. It is the only system capable of detecting rises in sea levels due to global warming caused by the